

Guidance

Recyclability assessment methodology: how to assess your packaging waste

An overview of the recyclability assessment methodology (RAM). Under extended producer responsibility for packaging, large producers must report the recyclability of some packaging materials

From: **Department for Environment, Food & Rural Affairs** (</government/organisations/department-for-environment-food-rural-affairs>), **Environment Agency** (</government/organisations/environment-agency>) and **Natural Resources Wales** (</government/organisations/natural-resources-wales>)

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From 1 January 2025, liable producers who supply [household packaging](https://www.gov.uk/guidance/extended-producer-responsibility-for-packaging-how-to-assess-household-and-non-household-packaging) (<https://www.gov.uk/guidance/extended-producer-responsibility-for-packaging-how-to-assess-household-and-non-household-packaging>), packaging that commonly ends up in public bins or household drinks containers made of glass must assess the recyclability of that packaging and report the results of the assessment to the environmental regulator.

[Find out about EPR for packaging](https://www.gov.uk/government/collections/extended-producer-responsibility-for-packaging-report-packaging-data) (<https://www.gov.uk/government/collections/extended-producer-responsibility-for-packaging-report-packaging-data>). This collection of guidance includes information on who is affected ('liable'), what data to collect and how to report

To do this, you will need to assess packaging you supply using the recyclability assessment methodology (RAM).

This Version 1.1 of RAM, published in April 2025. [Find out more about versions of the RAM and how it is updated](https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/methodology-asesu-aigylchadwyedd-cyhoeddwyd-rhagfyr-2024). The RAM is also available [in Welsh \(Cymraeg\)](https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/methodology-asesu-aigylchadwyedd-cyhoeddwyd-rhagfyr-2024) (<https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/methodology-asesu-aigylchadwyedd-cyhoeddwyd-rhagfyr-2024>).

Different kinds of packaging receive different ratings - **red**, **amber** or **green**. This rating affects the disposal fee that will be charged for that packaging. This is sometimes called 'fee modulation'.

This is an overview of the RAM. You should read this guide alongside other RAM information that covers:

- [RAM ratings and outputs for different packaging materials](https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/recycling-assessment-methodology-materials-and-outputs) (<https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/recycling-assessment-methodology-materials-and-outputs>)
- [definitions and background](https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/recycling-assessment-methodology-background-and-definitions) (<https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/recycling-assessment-methodology-background-and-definitions>) - this explains the stages of recyclability and some technical terms

- [clarifications and additional information \(https://www.gov.uk/guidance/recyclability-assessment-methodology-supplementary-guidance\)](https://www.gov.uk/guidance/recyclability-assessment-methodology-supplementary-guidance) to help you carry out your RAM assessment
- the [RAM decision tree \(https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/recyclability-assessment-methodology-decision-tree-diagram\)](https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/recyclability-assessment-methodology-decision-tree-diagram)

Recyclability assessment data: June 2025 regulatory position statement

The environmental regulators have issued a statement on collecting and reporting data under the RAM.

This only applies to Recyclability Assessment Methodology (RAM) data collection and reporting. It does not apply to any other data you must collect and report for EPR for packaging.

Read [PackUK's statement on recyclability assessment \(https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/packuk-common-2025-recyclability-assessment-requirements/packuk-2025-recyclability-assessment-requirements\)](https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/packuk-common-2025-recyclability-assessment-requirements/packuk-2025-recyclability-assessment-requirements). This links to regulatory position statements from each of the four regulators. Check the statement from your regulator to understand how this affects your data submission.

Report flexible and rigid subtypes of plastics even if you are not submitting recyclability data.

Who has to do this

Only large producers (also known as 'large organisations') must collect and report their recyclability assessment data. [Find out about small and large producers \(https://www.gov.uk/guidance/extended-producer-responsibility-for-packaging-who-is-affected-and-what-to-do#what-you-may-need-to-do\)](https://www.gov.uk/guidance/extended-producer-responsibility-for-packaging-who-is-affected-and-what-to-do#what-you-may-need-to-do).

What packaging you must assess

You only need to collect and report recyclability assessment data if you supply [household packaging \(https://www.gov.uk/guidance/extended-producer-responsibility-for-packaging-how-to-assess-household-and-non-household-packaging\)](https://www.gov.uk/guidance/extended-producer-responsibility-for-packaging-how-to-assess-household-and-non-household-packaging), packaging that commonly ends up in public bins or household

drinks containers made of glass.

Categories of material

There are 8 categories for materials. These are often called 'specified materials'.

- [paper and board](https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/recycling-assessment-methodology-materials-and-outputs/recycling-assessment-methodology-assessing-materials#paper-and-board) (<https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/recycling-assessment-methodology-materials-and-outputs/recycling-assessment-methodology-assessing-materials#paper-and-board>)
- [fibre-based composite materials](https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/recycling-assessment-methodology-materials-and-outputs/recycling-assessment-methodology-assessing-materials#fibre-based-composite-materials) (<https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/recycling-assessment-methodology-materials-and-outputs/recycling-assessment-methodology-assessing-materials#fibre-based-composite-materials>)
- plastic - there is separate guidance for [rigid plastics](https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/recycling-assessment-methodology-materials-and-outputs/recycling-assessment-methodology-assessing-materials#plastic-rigids) (<https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/recycling-assessment-methodology-materials-and-outputs/recycling-assessment-methodology-assessing-materials#plastic-rigids>) and [flexible plastics](https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/recycling-assessment-methodology-materials-and-outputs/recycling-assessment-methodology-assessing-materials#plastic-flexibles) (<https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/recycling-assessment-methodology-materials-and-outputs/recycling-assessment-methodology-assessing-materials#plastic-flexibles>)
- [steel](https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/recycling-assessment-methodology-materials-and-outputs/recycling-assessment-methodology-assessing-materials#steel) (<https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/recycling-assessment-methodology-materials-and-outputs/recycling-assessment-methodology-assessing-materials#steel>)
- [aluminium](https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/recycling-assessment-methodology-materials-and-outputs/recycling-assessment-methodology-assessing-materials#aluminium) (<https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/recycling-assessment-methodology-materials-and-outputs/recycling-assessment-methodology-assessing-materials#aluminium>)
- [glass](https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/recycling-assessment-methodology-materials-and-outputs/recycling-assessment-methodology-assessing-materials#glass) (<https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/recycling-assessment-methodology-materials-and-outputs/recycling-assessment-methodology-assessing-materials#glass>)
- [wood](https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/recycling-assessment-methodology-materials-and-outputs/recycling-assessment-methodology-assessing-materials#wood) (<https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/recycling-assessment-methodology-materials-and-outputs/recycling-assessment-methodology-assessing-materials#wood>)
- [other](https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/recycling-assessment-methodology-materials-and-outputs/recycling-assessment-methodology-assessing-materials#other) (<https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/recycling-assessment-methodology-materials-and-outputs/recycling-assessment-methodology-assessing-materials#other>)

Each unit of packaging or component should be assessed under one of these categories.

Separate guidance explains [how to apply the RAM to each category of](#)

[material \(https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/recycling-assessment-methodology-materials-and-outputs\)](https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/recycling-assessment-methodology-materials-and-outputs). Use that guidance to assess whether your packaging unit or component is **red**, **amber** or **green**.

Outputs: the red, amber, green scale

In addition to the material category, packaging will fall into one of 3 categories:

- **red** packaging has specifications that make it difficult to recycle at scale
- **amber** packaging may experience challenges during collection and sortation, requires specialist infrastructure for reprocessing, the efficiency and output quality of reprocessing is affected, or there is some secondary material loss
- **green** packaging is widely recyclable in the current UK infrastructure

There are separate codes for medical packaging. Read the guidance below for more details.

Materials that are exempt

Some packaging is exempt from a recyclability assessment:

- reused packaging, unless it has been imported into the United Kingdom
- any packaging exported from the United Kingdom by the producer
- drinks containers made of polyethylene terephthalate (PET) plastic, steel or aluminium
- drinks containers for which a deposit is payable and is within scope of a DRS which is in operation
- non-household packaging

Automatic reds ('problematic packaging')

Some packaging and components of packaging always count as **red** on the scale.

Items of packaging or components must be classified as **red** if they contain

any of the following above the limit of detection and they have been intentionally added:

- integrated electrical components or batteries that would be classed as Electrical and Electronic Equipment (EEE) - for example, boxes that include LED lights
- any of the substances of very high concern (SVHC) above the specified thresholds set out under [UK REACH \(https://www.hse.gov.uk/reach/about.htm\)](https://www.hse.gov.uk/reach/about.htm)
- inks that are not manufactured in compliance with the EuPIA [Exclusion Policy for Printing Inks and Related products \(https://www.eupia.org/wp-content/uploads/2024/11/Ed7_ExclusionPolicy_final.pdf\)](https://www.eupia.org/wp-content/uploads/2024/11/Ed7_ExclusionPolicy_final.pdf)
- any household packaging within scope of the RAM which has not been assessed or where the detail required to undertake an assessment isn't available

If perfluoroalkyl and Polyfluoroalkyl Substances (PFAS) have been intentionally added to packaging, this is also an automatic **red**. However, this does not apply if the predominant material is aluminium, steel or glass.

Medical packaging

Medical packaging is immediate or outer packaging on:

- medicinal products
- veterinary medicinal products
- medical devices

Immediate packaging that is in immediate contact with the product.

Outer packaging is any packaging into which the immediate packaging is placed.

You can find out more about [medicinal products in the Human Medicines Regulations 2012 \(https://www.legislation.gov.uk/ukxi/2012/1916/regulation/2/made\)](https://www.legislation.gov.uk/ukxi/2012/1916/regulation/2/made).

If you are uncertain whether a product counts as medical, check with the Medicines and Healthcare products Regulatory Agency (MHRA). They publish guidance that explains [how to tell if your product is a medicine \(https://www.gov.uk/guidance/borderline-products-how-to-tell-if-your-product-is-a-](https://www.gov.uk/guidance/borderline-products-how-to-tell-if-your-product-is-a-)

[medicine](#)).

Medical packaging must be reported under different codes:

- **red - medical**
- **amber - medical**
- **green - medical**

If you assess your medical packaging as **red - medical** and that it must be **red - medical** because of a regulatory requirement, then it can be reported as **amber - medical**. You must have evidence for this.

If you assess your medical packaging as **red - medical** and this is not because of a regulatory requirement, it will be subject to modulation in the same way as other red-rated packaging materials.

How this will affect what you pay ('modulation')

Find out about [modulated disposal fees \(https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/extended-producer-responsibility-for-packaging-modulated-disposal-fees\)](https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/extended-producer-responsibility-for-packaging-modulated-disposal-fees).

What you must report in 2025

You need to submit recyclability assessment data about all [household packaging \(https://www.gov.uk/guidance/extended-producer-responsibility-for-packaging-how-to-assess-household-and-non-household-packaging\)](https://www.gov.uk/guidance/extended-producer-responsibility-for-packaging-how-to-assess-household-and-non-household-packaging) that you supply.

Find out [what packaging data you have to collect for EPR for packaging \(https://www.gov.uk/guidance/how-to-collect-your-packaging-data-for-extended-producer-responsibility\)](https://www.gov.uk/guidance/how-to-collect-your-packaging-data-for-extended-producer-responsibility).

You must enter the results of your assessment on the packaging data file that you submit to the regulator through the [report packaging data \(https://www.gov.uk/guidance/report-packaging-data\)](https://www.gov.uk/guidance/report-packaging-data) service. There are details on how to do this in the guidance that explains [how to create your file for EPR for packaging \(https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/package-data-how-to-create-your-file-for-extended-producer-responsibility\)](https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/package-data-how-to-create-your-file-for-extended-producer-responsibility).

The environmental regulators have issued a statement on collecting and reporting data under the RAM. This only applies to Recyclability Assessment Methodology (RAM) data collection and reporting. It does not apply to any other data you must collect and report for EPR for packaging. Read the [PackUK position statement \(https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/packuk-common-2025-recyclability-assessment-requirements/packuk-2025-recyclability-assessment-requirements\)](https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/packuk-common-2025-recyclability-assessment-requirements/packuk-2025-recyclability-assessment-requirements) to understand how this affects your data submission.

If you need help assessing your packaging

If you do not know what the packaging you supply is made of or are missing other technical details that you need to complete the assessment, contact the packaging manufacturer.

You can also contact a third party provider for advice on your EPR packaging obligations including making and reporting the results of your recyclability assessments. Third party providers are likely to charge a fee for this.

RAM versions and updates

The RAM will be reviewed and updated annually. This is to allow for innovation, evolving market conditions and regulatory changes.

The update will happen in the autumn before the reporting year it applies to.

This version of the RAM: 1.1

This is RAM version 1.1 (April 2025). This simplifies the first version, which was published in December 2024. Major changes are noted in the appropriate section.

Who decides these ratings

There is a RAM Technical Advisory Committee (TAC) that advises PackUK on the annual review of the RAM. The TAC is an advisory body made up a broad cross section of the packaging value chain. It supports PackUK to assess any planned changes to the RAM.

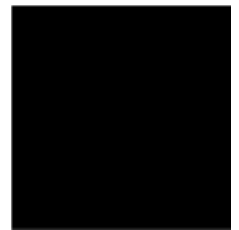
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